THEOGONY

Let us begin to sing of the Muses of Helicon first, who
Have and inhabit their shrine on that large and numinous mountain.
Furthermore, round some spring that is violet-colored, on tender
Feet they are dancing or round the altar of Zeus the almighty,
Bathing their delicate skin in the spring of Permessus or in the
Spring of the horse[1] or of sacred Olmeius; they often create their
Lovely and beautiful dances on top of Mount Helicon's summit.
Thence they arise and they go forth wholly enveloped in darkness,
Walking abroad in the night, projecting their beautiful voices,
Singing of Zeus, who sustains the aegis, and reverend Hera,
Lady of Argos[2]—wherever she wanders, her sandals are golden—
Hymning the daughter of Zeus, who carries the aegis, Athena
With gray eyes, and Apollo and Artemis, lover of arrows,
Also Poseidon, who holds the earth and occasionally shakes it,
Reverend Themis[3] and coy Aphrodite, who glances askance, too,
Beautiful Hebe,[4] whose garland is gold and lovely, Dione,[5]

1. Pegasus, the winged horse from whose hooves many a sacred spring sprang. Springs are generally sacred to the Muses, who may originally have been water sprites, nymphs, or naiads.

2. Argos, in the Peloponnesus, was sacred to Hera (Zeus's third wife), as Athens was to Athena, etc. Most cities had their special, tutelary deity.

3. "Justice" or "Steadfast," Zeus's second wife; a partial personification, like Hebe (Youth).

4. "Youth," a minor deity; in Homer, the cupbearer of the Gods and heavenly wife of Heracles.

5. Mother of Aphrodite in some versions.

Leto,[6] Iapetus, also Cronus, whose counsel is crooked,
Dawn, the magnificent Sun, and the Moon, with her radiant visage,
Earth, and the might of the Ocean, and Night, who personifies blackness,
All of the sacred race of immortals enduring forever.
Such are the goddesses who taught Hesiod beautiful songs once
While he was shepherding lambs in the shadow of Helicon's holy
Mountain, and these were the very first words they uttered to me, those
Nymphs of Olympus, the daughters of Zeus, who carries the aegis.
"Wilderness shepherds, ignoble excuses for men, merely bellies.
We are accustomed to tell many lies that resemble the facts, and
We are accustomed to speak, when we wish to, the literal truth, too."
So the articulate daughters of Zeus the magnificent spoke, and
Gave me a staff, a sprout they had plucked of the vigorous laurel:
It was a marvelous thing. They inspired me with vocal, prophetic
Song, to enunciate matters to come and others that have been.
Me they commanded to sing of the race of the blessed immortals,
Hymning themselves at beginning and end of every poem.
What is, however, to me all that stuff about oak trees and stones?

You, then, let us begin with the Muses who up on Olympus
Pleasure with music the mighty mind of our heavenly father,
Telling of things as they are, as they will be, and were in aforetime,
Blending their voices which flow inexhaustibly sweet from their open
Mouths; then the home of their father, loud-thundering Zeus, is delighted.
Glad at the delicate, far flung tone of the Muses, the peaks of
Snowy Olympus and all the abodes of the deathless reecho.
Raising aloft their ambrosial voices in song, they extol the
Worshipful race of the gods first, whom at the very beginning
Earth and extensive Heaven gave birth to: the gods were their children,

6. Latona in Latin, mother of Artemis and Apollo.

Givers of good things. Second, they sing about almighty Zeus, the
Father of gods and of men, thus beginning and ending their song, for
Zeus is the highest and best of the gods and the greatest in power.
Next, the Olympian Muses, the daughters of Zeus with the aegis,
Pleasure with music the mind of Zeus, who inhabits Olympus,
Singing a song of the races of humans and powerful giants.
Them in Pieria Memory, queen of the hills of Eleuther,[7]
After she lay with the father of gods, the descendant of Cronus,
Bore as a respite from woe and a means of forgetting all sorrow.
Zeus, the astute great counselor, slept with Mnemosyne[8] nine nights,
Going up into her blessed bed far from the other immortals.
Then, when a year had passed and the round of the seasons was perfect,
After the months dwindled down and the number of days was
accomplished,
Memory bore nine daughters whose hearts were intent upon music;
All were unanimous also, their spirits remarkably carefree,
At birth little removed from the summit of snowy Olympus.
There were their glistening dancing-floors next to their beautiful
houses.
Near them the Graces as well as Desire had homes in delightful
Comfort. The Muses, projecting their lovely voices from their mouths,
Sing of the customs and noble characters of the immortals.
They, as they went to Olympus, rejoiced in their beautiful voices
And their ambrosial melody. Around them the dark earth rang out
Loudly in time to their hymns. Sweet noises arose from their footsteps
As they progressed to their father, who ruled as a monarch in heaven,
Holding the terrible thunderbolt, grasping the glittering lightning.
After he conquered with violence Cronus, his father, he parceled
Out each his role to the gods and apportioned their duties and honors.

7. "Freetown," on the border of Attica and Boeotia.

8. Mnemosyne and Memory are, of course, one and the same; these first gods, or Titans, are a curious mix of personifications and cult names.

This was the song of the Muses, who make their homes on Olympus,
Nine of them, daughters engendered of almighty Zeus. And their names were
Cleio, Euterpe, and Thalia, also Melpomene, and her
Sister Terpsichore, lovely Erato, Polymnia, likewise
Blessed Urania, also Calliope, first of the Muses.[9]
She is a handmaid waiting on reverend princes. If any
One of these heavenly-nurtured princes the daughters of mighty
Zeus should be pleased to regard, on beholding him when he is newborn,
Over the tongue of that child they distill sweet liquor from heaven,
Out of his mouth flow honey-sweet words. And then all of the people
Look to the same who decides between differing sides with unbending
Righteousness; speaking decisively, firmly, he can in a little
While understandingly put an end even to serious quarrels.
This is the function of sensible kings, that whenever the people
Err in assembly, the kings set right the affairs of the people
Easily, talking them over with soft words, gentle persuasion.
Making his way through the throng, he is greeted and cheered like a god, with
Honeyed respect, and he stands out always when people assemble.
Such is the holy and glorious gift of the Muses to mankind,
For it is thanks to the Muses and to far-darting Apollo
That there are singers and poets on earth and performers on harps; but
Kings are descended from Zeus, who is happy whomever the Muses
Love and befriend, from whose mouth flows speech that is sweeter than honey.
So, if a person through harboring grief in his freshly bereaved mind
Parches his heart with incessant distress, and a wandering minstrel

9. Literally, more or less, "Fame," "Charm," "Plenty," "Sweet-singer," "Delightful dancer," "Lovely," "Polyphony," "Heavenly," "Fair-faced"; whether these names were traditional or Hesiod's invention we cannot, of course, tell, but they sound made up. The functions of each were not assigned till later.

Serving the Muses then sings of the glorious doings of former
Men and of blessed immortals who hold and inhabit Olympus,
Instantly he will forget disagreeable thoughts and remember
Nothing of sorrow; the gifts of the goddesses swiftly divert him.
Hail to the children of Zeus, who give us delectable song and
Publish the holy descent of immortals existing forever,
Those that of old were engendered of Earth and of star-spangled Heaven
Or of mysterious Night, even those that were bred by the salt sea.
Tell now how did the gods and the earth first come into being,
Rivers as well, and the limitless sea with its storm-driven swells, and
Also the twinkling stars and the widespread heaven above all.
Tell how the gods then divided their wealth and appointed their riches,
How they at first got hold of the heights of wrinkled Olympus.
Tell me of these things, Muses that dwell on the heights of Olympus,
From the beginning, and say which first of them came into being.

First of all, Chaos came into existence; thereafter, however,
Broad-bosomed earth took form, the forever immovable seat of
All of the deathless gods who inhabit the heights of Olympus,
And murky Tartarus,[10] tucked in a cleft of extensively traveled
Earth; also Eros,[11] most beautiful god among all the immortals,
Loosening limbs, dominating the hearts and the minds and the well-laid
Plans both of all the immortals and all of susceptible mankind.
Next, out of Chaos, with Erebus,[12] black Night too was engendered,
And out of Night were the Aether and Daylight together begotten,
Whom she conceived after lying with Erebus lovingly, and bore.

10. The underworld; see below, lines 730–40.

11. Love, Cupid in Latin, son of Aphrodite, the abstract son of a primordial mother; causing one to wonder whether such personifications came first or were back-formations from a common verb, as here.

12. Another hell-realm, from an Indo-European root for "darkness."

Earth to begin with engendered her firstborn, star-studded Heaven,
Equal in size to herself, to conceal her on every side, in
Order to furnish a solid foundation for the blessed forever.
Next she gave birth to immense, high mountains, the pleasant retreats of
Goddesses, nymphs who inhabit the glens of the mountainous
woodlands.
Also she bore the unfathomable deep with its wind-driven swells, the
Sea, but without the assistance of love or desire; after she had
Slept with Uranus (the Sky), she gave birth to the eddying Ocean,
Coios and Creios, Hyperion, Iapetus, Thea and Rhea,
Themis, Mnemosyne, golden-wreathed Phoebe, and lovable Tethys;
Heaven and Earth[13] bore, last of their children, intelligent Cronus,
Their most redoubtable offspring, who hated his vigorous father.

Earth gave birth to the Cyclopses, superabundant in life force,
Thunder, Lightning, and Flash, who was powerful and stout hearted,
Furnishing thunder to Zeus, manufacturing thunderbolts for him.
Similar were they in every other respect to the gods,
Save that a singular eye was set in the midst of their foreheads.
Cyclopses were their eponymous nicknames, which is to say, "Round
Eyes,"
Seeing a singular circular eye was set in their foreheads.
Physical strength, brute force, and mechanical cunning their works
showed.
Three other sons were engendered by Heaven and Earth, who were very
Mighty and powerful, not to be lightly or frequently mentioned,
Cottus, Briareus, Gyges, unruly and troublesome children,
For from their shoulders a hundred hands unattractively sprouted.
Likewise there grew from the shoulders of each fifty heads on their sturdy
Bodies. A strength irresistible went with their awful appearance.

13. Gaia, eldest of beings after Chaos, gave birth to the sky (Uranus) and the sea, compared to which these Titans are of secondary importance, unless noted elsewhere.

Such were the terrible children begotten by Heaven on Earth and
Loathed from the first by their very own father, who, when they were infants,
Tucked them away in a hole in the earth and prevented their coming
Up to the light; and Uranus rejoiced in his own evildoing.
Earth, though gigantic, was painfully stuffed on the inside and groaned out
Loud. She was quick to develop a scheme both cunning and wicked;
Swiftly creating an element, gray-colored iron, of it she
Fashioned a great big sickle, and said to her dearly loved children,
Speaking out boldly, courageously, although afraid in her own heart,
"My dear children, begotten, alas! of a reprobate father,
Listen to me and obey: let us punish your father's wrongdoing;
He was the first to conceive of disgraceful and criminal conduct."
That's what she said. They were all of them frozen by fear, so that no one
Uttered a word, until mighty, intelligent Cronus took courage,
And he addressed in the following words his worshipful mother:
"Mother, I would undertake to accomplish this deed, for I haven't
Any respect at all for our wretched, unspeakable father,
Who was the first to conceive such disgraceful and criminal conduct."
So he declared, and magnificent Earth was heartily gladdened.
Taking her son by the hand, Earth hid him in ambush, and put a
Serrated scythe in his hand, and disclosed to him wholly her dire plot.
Ushering night in, Uranus visited Gaia,[14] desiring
Amorous intimacy; he extended himself all around and
Over the earth, while his son from his ambush protruded his left hand;
Taking the formidable broad serrated blade in his right, he
Hastily cut off his own father's privates and cast them behind him.
Nor did they fly from his hand without profit, for Gaia accepted
All of the blood drops gushing therefrom. When the year was completed,

14. Heaven and Earth personified, respectively.

Earth gave birth to the Furies as well as the big, strong giants,
Splendid in armor and carrying lances and swords in their large hands,
Also the nymphs that are called after ash trees over the boundless
Earth. So when Cronus had cut off those members with iron, he threw them
Straightaway down from the dry land into the tumultuous sea surge,
Where they were carried along on the turbulent surface a long time.
Round the divine flesh rose up a colorless foam, whence a maiden
Grew; who at first by the holy island of Cythera drifted,
Coming at length and at last to the wave-bound island of Cyprus,
Where the inspiring and beautiful goddess set foot, and the grass grew
Under her tapering feet, whom immortals and mortals together
Call Aphrodite, because she was born from the spume of the sea, and
Beautifully wreathed Cytherea, since she arrived at Cythera;
Cyprus-engendered, because she was born on the sea-isle of Cyprus;
Genital-loving, because she had sprung from sexual organs.
Eros accompanied her; she was followed by comely Desire when
First she was born, and she entered at once the immortals' assembly.
Such were the honors allotted to her from the very beginning.
This was the destined business she played among men and immortals:
Maidenly whispers and smiles and giggles and girlish deception,
Pleasure exquisitely pleasant and love that is sweeter than honey.

Mighty Uranus, who was their father, sarcastically named the
Sons he himself had begotten, collectively, "strenuous Titans,"
Saying they'd striven outrageously, strenuously to perform a
Terrible deed, one for which they would surely be punished hereafter.

Night also bore reprehensible Doom and her relative, black Fate;[15]
She was delivered of Death and of Sleep and the legions of nightmares.
Afterward pitch-black Night, who'd had intercourse really with no one,

15. Why Fate is a single goddess here and three goddesses just below is unclear; a certain inconsistency must be apparent by now, not only in the genealogies.

Gave birth to bitter Reproach and to Suffering, painful and poignant,
And the Hesperides,[16] who tend beautiful, golden, delicious
Apples beyond illustrious Ocean, and fruit-bearing trees, too;
Also she bore the implacable punishing Furies, and three Fates,
Clotho, Lachesis, and Atropos,[17] who at the hour of their birth give
Mankind their personal rations of bad luck and good for their lifetime.
As for the Furies, they prosecute human transgressions, divine, too;
Nor do these goddesses ever relinquish their terrible anger
Till they repay with maleficent scrutiny every sinner.
Also deplorable Night bore Nemesis, who is the bane of
Mortals, and then, in succession, Deception as well as Affection;
Likewise, lamentable Old Age bore she, and hard-hearted Conflict.
Yet was despicable Conflict the mother of dolorous labor,
Brutish forgetfulness, hunger and pains that reduce one to tears, and
Battles and fights of all kinds, like homicide, manslaughter, murder,
Quarrels and lies, hard words, altercations, disputes, even lawsuits,
Civil disorder, and ruin, which go by their nature together,
Finally, Oath, which of all things on earth worst punishes men when
Anyone perjures himself deliberately and is forsworn.

Nereus,[18] true, unforgetful, and honest, was born of the Sea, the
Eldest of all of his children, so sometimes they call him the Old Man,
For he is truthful and gentle and never forgetful of justice,
Seeing that all of his knowledge tends toward kindness and healing.
Magical Thaumas[19] and arrogant Phorcys[20] again he engendered,
After he coupled with Earth, in addition to pretty-cheeked Ceto,

16. The daughters of Evening (Hesperus), which is to say, the West; their golden apples were possibly oranges.

17. She who spins, she who distributes, and she who is not to be averted.

18. Grandfather of Achilles; this sea-god wrestled with Heracles, changing shapes and, indeed, substances, from water to fire, etc.

19. The root of his name means "magic" or "marvel," hence the adjective.

20. Father, with his sister Ceto, of, besides the monsters mentioned below, the Sirens and Tritons.

Handsome Eurybia, with an immoveable heart in her bosom.
These are the loveliest goddesses ever conceived in the fallow
Sea, and begotten by Nereus, mingled in passion with well-kempt
Doris, the daughter of Ocean, that perfectly circular river:
Ploto, Eucrante, and Sao, together with great Amphitrite,
Kindly Eudora, and Thetis, Galena and Glauce, the gray eyed,
And Cymothoe and Speio, and Thoe and Halia, lovely-
Faced Pasithea, Erato, and Eunice whose arms are outstandingly rosy,
Charming Melite and fair Eulimena and gracious Agave,
Doto and Proto and pleasing Pherousa and swift Dynamena,
Nisaea also, Actaea and Protomedea and Doris,
And Panopea and gorgeously formed Galatea and rosy-
Armed Hipponoe and sexy and sweet Hippothoe, as well as
Slick Cymodoke, who smooths out the billows and blasts of the goodly
Winds on the fog-covered face of the deep with Cymatolege's
Help and the help of neat-ankled, divine Amphitrite;
Cymo and also Eione and beautifully wreathed Alimede,
Plus Glauconome, whose pleasure is laughter, and Pontoporea
And Leagora, Euagora, Leomedea and fair Polynoe,
Lysianassa, Euarne (lovely to look at and wholesome
Naturally) and Psamathe as well with her perfect complexion,
Heavenly Menippe, Neso, Eupompe, Themisto, Pronoe,
Lastly Nemertes, whose intellect equals her deathless papa's.
These are the daughters of Nereus, knowledgeable in all good works.
Thaumas was wed to Electra, a daughter of deep-rolling Ocean,
Who was the mother of swift-footed Iris[21] as well as the hairy
Harpies, Aello and swift Ocypetes, whose quick-moving wings kept
Up with the blasts of the winds and the birds, flying quickly as time flies.
Ceto delivered to Phorcys the Graiai with beautiful faces,
Who had been gray-haired since birth, so that both the immortals and
mortal

21. Messenger of the gods.

Men who inhabit the whole earth call them "old women" or Graiai,
Violet-garbed Pamphedo, Eyo whose garment is saffron;
Also the Gorgons, who dwell far beyond the illustrious ocean
Out on the borders of night with the shrill-voiced daughters of evening,
These being Sthenno, Euryale, and gruesome Medusa, who suffered
Grievously: she was the one who was mortal, the others immortal.
But with Medusa alone black-haired Poseidon would lie in
Deep and luxuriant meadows amid all the flowers of springtime.
Later, when Perseus cut off her head, there sprang from her blood great
Chrysaor, also the winged horse Pegasus, namely, the "Spring-Sprung,"
Seeing he sprang from the springs that surround the headwaters of ocean.
Chrysaor (Gold Sword)[22] was so called from his grasping a golden
Sword. Winged Pegasus, flying away, left behind him the earth, the
Mother of flocks, and approached the immortals and dwells in the halls of
Zeus, where he brings that dispenser of council his thunder and lightning.
Meanwhile, Chrysaor, having seduced Callirhoe, the daughter of far-famed
Ocean, begot fell Geryon, who had three heads on his shoulders,
Whom overmuscular Heracles killed on the isle Erytheia[23]
The same day that he drove off his broad-browed, rambling cattle
Even to blessed Tyrins, traversing the fords of the ocean
After he'd murdered the herdsman, Eurytion, also his kinsman
Orthus, who lived in a dim homestead beyond glorious Ocean.
Ceto gave birth to another impossible monster resembling

22. Though this etymology is sound, the foregoing is not. Pegasus seems to be a pre-Greek word. A golden sword was also an adjunct of various later divinities and semi-divinities, such as Apollo, Demeter, and Orpheus.

23. It was one of the labors of Hercules, to give him his Latin name, to rustle the cattle of this monster, at the bidding of Heracles' stepmother, Hera, whose place in his own name gives rise to conjecture. Tyrins is not far from Argos and Lerna.

Neither in any respect mere mortals or godly immortals,
Deep in a cavernous hole in the earth, strong-minded Echidna;
Half of her looked like a nymph, bright-glancing and fair of complexion,
Half of her looked like a monstrous serpent, tremendous and dread with
Spots on her skin, who devoured raw flesh in the bowels of blessed earth.
There was her cave underneath an immovable hollowed-out boulder,
Far from the regions of men, who are mortal, and gods, who are deathless;
There the Olympians gave her a glorious dwelling to live in
Under the soil of Arima[24] in watchfulness, gruesome Echidna;
Deathless and ageless that nymph lives all of the days of her lifetime.
And with that bright-eyed maiden there coupled in sexual union,
So it is said, overbearing and lawless and terrible Typhon.[25]
Pregnant, Echidna gave birth to the following murderous children.
Orthus was first to be born, fell Geryon's bloodthirsty hound dog.
Second, she bore an indomitable, an unspeakable monster,
Cerberus, eater of raw flesh, Hades'[26] stentorian watchdog.
Cerberus had fifty heads[27] and was insolent, reckless, and mighty.
Third, she gave birth to the Hydra of Lerna,[28] with grisly ideas,
Nurtured by white-armed Hera's implacable hatred for strong-armed
Heracles (heir of Amphitryon, by-blow of Zeus),[29] who destroyed the
Beast with his pitiless bronze sword, helped by Iolaus and wily,

24. In Italy.

25. Typhoon, the hurricane personified.

26. Note that Hades was a person and not a place.

27. In later literature and art, Cerberus has only three heads.

28. A marsh in the Argolid. We still say "hydra-headed" in memory of this multiple-headed monster.

29. Heracles, the most popular hero of the Greek world, was a Theban by birth. His mother was Alcmene and his father Amphytrion, but heroes were often said to be the sons of Zeus. His celebrated labors included, besides those mentioned, dragging Cerberus up from hell and taking him back.

Warlike Athena. The Hydra gave birth to Chimaera, a great and
Terrible creature, exhaling unquenchable fire, fleet footed,
Strong, who possessed three heads, of which one was a hideous lion's,
One was a goat's, and the third was a serpent's, a dangerous dragon,
Lion in front, at the tail end a snake, and a goat in the middle,
Breathing a blast incandescent and blazing of withering fire.
Noble Bellerophon[30] slew the Chimaera with Pegasus's aid.
But then the Hydra, submitting to Orthus, gave birth to the deadly
Sphinx, the destruction of Thebes, and the lion that wasted Nemea,[31]
Whom most respectable Hera, the consort of Zeus, educated
For devastating the foothills of Mount Nemea, a pest for
Men, as it preyed on the tribes of mankind who inhabited that land,
Lording it over Apesa and Tretus in hilly Nemea;
Nevertheless, the superior strength of great Heracles whipped it.
Finally, Ceto, united in sexual congress with Phorcys,
Brought forth a terrible serpent, which down in the hollows of dark
earth,
On its titanic perimeter, watches the solid gold apples;
This is the fabulous progeny born to Ceto and Phorcys.

Tethys[32] gave birth to the following turbulent rivers by Ocean,
Namely, the Nile and the Alpheius, also the deep Eridanus,
Strymon, Menander, as well as the beautiful streams of the Danube,
Phasis and Rhesus and swift Achelous with its silvery current.
Nessus and Rhodion, deep Haliacmon and swift Heptaporos,
Granicus, even Aesopus and equally holy Simois,

30. The many stories about this Corinthian hero include elements from the biblical Joseph's encounter with Potiphar's wife and the story of Icarus, who also tried to fly to heaven and failed. His genealogy is laid out in the Iliad (6155 ff). He accomplished his trials with the aid of the winged horse Pegasus, a gift from Athena.

31. A broad valley on the north of the Argolid; here Heracles performed another of his labors, slaying a lion sent by Hera.

32. Sister of Ocean, both children of Earth and Heaven.

Peneus. Hermus and mighty Suggaris, smooth-flowing Caicus,
Ladon, Parthenius, placid Ardescus and sacred Scamander.
Tethys gave birth to as well a divine generation of daughters
Who, on the earth, with his lordship Apollo as well as the rivers,[33]
Raise up the children of men, a vocation that Zeus has appointed:
Peitho, Admete, Ianthe, Electra and Doris and Prymno,
Heavenly looking Urania, Hippo and Clymene also,
Rhodeia and Callirhoe and Zeuxo and Clytie, Idyia
And Pasithoe, Plexaura, Galaxaura and winsome Dione,
Plus Melobosis and Thoe and sweet-to-behold Polydora,
Cerceis, naturally lovable Pluto, and cow-eyed Perseis,
Ianeira, Acaste and Xanthe, Petreia and lovely Menestho,
Also Europa and Metis, as well as Eurynome and, in her yellow
Tunic, Telestho, Chriseis and Asia, delightful Calypso,
Also Eudora and Tyche, Amphitro, and foremost of all, Styx.
These are the senior maidens born to the Ocean and Tethys,
But there are plenty of other trim-ankled and comely
Daughters of Ocean who, scattered about everywhere, altogether
Service the earth and the deeps of the waters, a glorious goddess's
Children, and such are the other abrupt loud-babbling rivers,
All of whose names it is hard for a man who is mortal to tell, but
Those who inhabit the country surrounding them know them in detail.

Theia, seduced by Hyperion, bore the magnificent Sun and
Radiant Moon, also Dawn, who appears to all dwellers on earth and
To the immortals, the gods who inhabit the spaces of heaven.
Lying in conjugal union with Crio, superb Eurybia
Bore to him mighty Astraeus and also magnificent Pallas,
Perses[34] as well, a preeminent sage as compared to all others.

33. The central role of rivers, as of Apollo, in the growth of civilization is more obvious than that of these sea nymphs.

34. Not to be confused with Hesiod's brother of the same name.

Eos conceived by Astraeus the strong-willed winds, when the goddess
Lay in delight with the god: these were Zephyr, the scouring west wind;
Boreas, rushing and fleet-footed north wind; and Notus, the south wind.
Afterward, early-born Eos gave birth to the stars that induct the
Dawn, and the rest of the glittering stars such as garland the heavens.
Styx, eldest daughter of Ocean, from sexual union with Pallas,
Bore to him emulous Zelos[35] and trim-ankled, victorious Nike
There in their halls, also Kratos and Bios, or Strength and innate Force,
Glorious children, whose home was not anywhere other than Zeus's,
Having no place and no way save where the divinity led them.
But they are dwelling forever at Zeus the deep thunderer's side, as
Styx, their unwithering mother, the daughter of Ocean, decided
On the same day the Olympian star-bright hurler of lightning
Summoned together the holy immortals to mighty Olympus,
Saying if one of the gods were to battle the Titans beside him,
He would not cast him aside from his rights, but that everyone should keep
All of his previous honors and offices with the immortals.
Further, he said that whoever had gone without honor or office
Under old Cronus would come into honors and offices justly.
Styx the undying was first of the gods in approaching Olympus,
Bringing her children, advised by her wise and affectionate father.
Zeus, in his gratitude, honored her, giving her excellent presents,
Making her function to serve as the solemn oath of the great gods,
Making her children for all of their days coinhabitants with him.
Such and in so many words was his promise, which he implemented
Thoroughly. Great is the power he wields, and his kingship is mighty.
Phoebe anon entered into the comfortable bed of Coeus,
Where she conceived the result of the love of a god for a goddess.

35. Envy personified, like Victory following, and the personifications in the next line.

Then she gave birth to subfusc-robed Leto, eternally pleasant,
Kind to all men that are mortal and gods who, of course, are immortal,
Pleasantest from the beginning, agreeably mild on Olympus.
Next, she gave birth to Asteria, well-named goddess whom Perses
Took home once to his marvelous house to be known as his dear wife.
She, being pregnant, gave birth unto Hecate hellcat, whom highest
Zeus, son of Cronus, esteemed, and he gave her splendiferous presents,
Namely, a part of the earth and her share in the fallow seabed;
She has an honorable place also in star-spangled heaven,
And she is glorified most of all by the gods, who are deathless.
So nowadays when one of the earth-dwelling brethren performs the
Beautiful rites in accordance with custom and prays to the gods, he
Calls upon Hecate. Full and abundant the honor that follows
Easily him whose prayers the considerate goddess receives well,
For of such as were born of the Earth and the Sky-God, she also
Garnered respect, and, of all, she possesses the lot that is her due.
Zeus, son of Cronus, in nothing abused her and took nothing from her
That was in gift to the Titanic gods who came earlier; rather,
She holds, as at first the initial division decided,
And wields her ancient rights on the earth, on the sea, and in heaven;
But yet much more still Zeus presents her in kindness:
Sitting by reverend kings enthroned, she assists them in judgment.
To him whom she wants to, she mightily gives good things in abundance.
So in the forum of folk, she advances the man whom she favors,
And when for mortal combat men buckle their cuirasses on,
Lo! there is Hecate also, and unto such men as she wishes,
Easily offers victory, loading her servants with honor.
Fair is she, likewise, when men contend in their beautiful contests,
For in that instance as well, she is present to honor and profit
One who by strength and by prowess prevails in athletics and will, with
Ease, win first prize and elatedly bring it back home to his parents.
Nobly she stands by the horsemen she favors, and as for the sailors,

Men who work hard on the gray, uncomfortable sea, when
Ever they pray unto her and the discordant, earth-moving Sea Lord,
Readily Hecate sends a great haul for their nets, but, should that be her pleasure,
Readily takes it away when she wishes as soon as they've seen it.
Also she helps in the barn beside Hermes in feeding the livestock,
Herding the cattle; she droves congregations of wandering goats and
Flocks of shambling sheep; if she wishes she may increase them
Or may diminish their number, making a few out of many.
Although Hecate is the unique child born of her mother,
Thereafter she will be honored among all the divine immortals.
Zeus, son of Cronus, appointed her nanny of all mortal children
Who with their own eyes thenceforth behold the light of observant
Dawn. She was from the beginning the nurse of these children, and therefore
Such were her honors. But Rhea, submitting to Cronus, bore splendid
Offspring: Hestia, also Demeter and Hera, whose sandals are golden,
Powerful, strong-armed Hades, who under the earth makes his dwelling—
Pitiless his disposition—and smashing and seismic Poseidon,
As well as Zeus, the far planner, father of gods and of humans,
Under the force of whose thunder the wide earth shivers in terror.
These every one great Cronus gobbled down whole as they issued
Each from the womb of their sacred mother to sit on her lap, for
Thus he intended that no one else of the children of heaven
Should wield regal authority ever among the immortals.
For he had learned from Earth and from star-spangled Heaven that he was
Doomed to be overcome by his very own son, namely Zeus,
Strong as he was, through the wiles of the same, though as yet unconceived, god.
On this account he mounted no purblind vigil, but watching
Out, he devoured his offspring. Terrible grief possessed Rhea

When she was going to bear Zeus, father of men and immortals;
Then she implored her own dear parents, star-strewn Heaven and Earth, to
Help her come up with some plan, how she might in secret give birth to
Her dear son, and how devious Cronus might pay retribution
For what he'd done to his father and for ingesting his children.
Thoroughly they understood and obeyed their favorite daughter.
They foretold to her everything that was fated to happen
Soon to his majesty Cronus as well as his strong-minded son.
They sent Rhea to Lyctos, in the fertile country of Crete.
When she was ready, she gave birth to the last of her children,
Great Zeus, and her Earth-mother took him from Rhea in broad Crete
To nourish the child and as maternal grandmother rear him.
Hastily Earth transported the newborn child through the dark night,
First into Lyctos, where taking the babe in her arms she concealed him
Deep in a high-roofed cave in the sacred earth in the hidden
Hollows beneath the luxuriant forests that clothe Mount Aegeum.
But to the earlier Lord of the gods, the scion of Heaven,
Earth proffered a great big rock that was wrapped up in swaddling
Bands, and he grabbed it and shoved it all the way down in his belly.
Nor did he guess in his heart that his son, unhurt and unvanquished,
Had been replaced by that stone, and by force and the strength of his hands would
Soon overcome him and take all his honors and rule the immortals.
Swiftly thereafter, the strength and the glorious limbs of the new and
Future king were augmented and grew. As the years in their passage
Rolled on, great Cronus, whose counsels are crooked, misled by
Gaia's subtle persuasions, vomited up his own offspring.
First, he brought up the stone, which was the last thing he had swallowed:
Zeus erected that stone in the midst of the wide-traveled earth at
Pytho, that great, good place, underneath the glens of Parnassus,
Set as a sign thereafter, a marvel to men, who are mortal.

Then he unloosed from their grievous bonds all Cronus's brothers,
Heaven's descendants, whom Cronus his father had thoughtlessly put down.
And they remembered their nephew in gratitude for all of his kind deeds
And in their gratitude gave him the thunder and dazzling lightning
Bolts which prodigious earth had concealed in her innermost parts. So,
Trusting in these dread weapons he rules both immortals and mortals.

Thereafter Iapetus married Clymene, beautiful daughter of Ocean,
Her of the shapely ankles,[36] and led her up their bedroom.
Clymene bore to her husband a stout-hearted son named Atlas.
Also she bore him Monoetius, highly respected, as well as
Clever, sharp-witted Prometheus, and Epimetheus, foolish
From the beginning, pernicious, an evil to bread-eating mortals.[37]
He was the first to receive from Zeus the maiden Pandora,
Whom he had fashioned. Outrageous Monoetius far-sighted Zeus sent
Down to Erebus, striking him low with an incandescent
Thunderbolt for his unreason and overwhelming presumption.
Atlas upholds the broad heavens by force of necessity at the
Ends of the earth, where he stands tall near the Hesperides, who sing
Purely, supporting the sky on his head and his muscular shoulders:
Such was the destiny that wise Zeus decided for Atlas.
He bound devious, wily Prometheus tightly in chains too
Tough to escape from, terrible bonds, and he skewered his middle.
Furthermore, on him he set a long-pinioned eagle to eat his
Immortal liver, which grew overnight just as much as that bird with
Tapering wings had eaten during the whole day preceding.

36. The obsession, here and elsewhere, with feminine ankles bespeaks the modesty of women of whom little else could be seen. It conduces also to some compound adjectives, such as "trim-ankled," that are clumsier in English than in Greek.

37. Two characteristics of human beings were stressed in ancient Greek: our mortality and our basic diet.

This big bird the courageous son of tapering-ankled Alcmene,
Heracles, killed, thus freeing Iapetus's son from that evil
Pest; on the spot, he released him from all his discomfort and torment,
With the connivance of paramount Zeus, king of Olympus,
So the renown and repute of Heracles, who was a Theban
Born, might increase even more over the generous earth.
Taking account of all this, Zeus honored his glorious son and,
Though he was angry indeed, he abated his previous anger
Because Prometheus flaunted the counsels of almighty Zeus.
Men had distinguished themselves from the gods at Mecone
First, when foresightful Prometheus brashly dissected a big ox,
Dishing up servings to each, and seeking to bamboozle smart Zeus.
Slyly, in front of the others, he set flesh, also the innards
Rich with the juiciest fat, near the hide, half-hid by the ox's
Belly; to Zeus he served white bones, which by artifice and low
Cunning he dished up disguised in the glistening fat of the bullock.
Then to Prometheus spoke the father of gods and of mankind:
"Son of Iapetus, most magnificent of all the princes,
See how invidiously, old son, you divided the servings."
So said thundering Zeus, everlastingly shrewd and all-knowing.
Crookedly scheming Prometheus answered him something as follows;
Slyly he smiled to himself as he thought of his crafty deception.
"Zeus, most honored and greatest of gods, whose race is forever,
Take of the pieces whichever the heart in your bosom inclines to."
So he declared as he pondered deceit, but Zeus, whose reflections
Are indestructible, knew and was quick to see through the deception,
And he foresaw in his heart much evil to follow for humans.
Taking the white fat up in both hands, Zeus grew very angry;
Anger possessed his mind the minute he noticed the ox's
White bones underneath and discovered Prometheus's crafty deception.
That is the reason the races of humans all over the earth burn
White bones to the blessed immortals on incense-redolent altars.
Then Zeus, who gathers the clouds, addressed him in bitter vexation,

"Iapetus's son, over all of the others exceedingly smart and
Knowledgeable, old fellow, you haven't forgotten your cunning!"
Zeus, being angry, spoke thus, with a deathless intention in mind, and,
Ever recalling the trick that was played on him, would not entrust the
Fierce inexhaustible fire to the hands of men, who must perish,
Creatures engendered of ash trees, who dwell on the face of the earth.
But Prometheus, Iapetus's brave son, thoroughly fooled him,
For he stole inexhaustible fire, whose blaze can be seen from
Far, in a hollow cane, which offended profoundly the mind of
Zeus, who thunders aloft, and his fond heart grew very angry
Seeing the twinkle of fire from afar among men, who are mortal.
Straightaway, Zeus prepared for them evil in place of purloined fire.
Famous Hephaestus,[38] the lame god, molded of water and earth the
Shape of a modest maiden by Zeus's advice and divine will.
Then Athena, the gray-eyed goddess, clad her and dressed her
Up in a silvery garment. Over her head she draped a
Finely embroidered veil with her hands, a most marvelous sight; with
Lovely garlands of new-grown wildflowers, Pallas Athena
Crowned her. Also, a garland of gold she put on her head, which
Famous Hephaestus the lame one himself devised with his own hands,
Artfully fashioning it as a favor to fatherly Zeus.
On it was wrought much intricate workmanship, wonderful to be
Seen; of the monstrous creatures such as the sea and the dry land
Nourish, he put many on it—so radiant beauty and splendor
Shone from it—creatures so lifelike one might suppose they had voices.
So when Hephaestus had made this beautiful bane in exchange for
Good, he conducted her to that place where the humans and gods were,
All tricked out by the gray-eyed daughter of powerful Zeus.
Wonderment seized the immortal gods and men who are mortal
When they beheld such a sheer deception and hardship for mankind;
But from her are descended untold generations of women.

38. Vulcan in Latin.

And from her you may trace the descent of the pestilent races of women;
Dwelling among mortal men, they occasion us plenty of trouble,
Bearing with us in prosperity, never in miserable hardship.
Likewise, in beetling beehives bees feed mischievous drones, for
Daily and all day long until sundown, while honeybees labor
Building the white wax honeycombs, drones on the other hand stay at
Home in the sheltering hive and gobble the labor of others.
Similarly did Zeus, who thunders aloft, create women,
Bad for mankind, in cahoots in all manner of tiresome mischief.
And he provided another bad thing in exchange for a good thing.
If, to avoid getting wed and the vexing behavior of women,
One doesn't go in for marriage, he arrives at lamentable old age
Lacking somebody to tend to him when he is old, and though he lacks
Nothing to live on when he is alive, at his death his relations,
Heirs to a vacant estate, will apportion his substance among them.
Yet on the other hand, for one who chooses the chances of marriage,
To have and to hold a respectable wife in accord with his wishes
From the beginning and through all his days, good squabbles with bad; for
Any who finds his children unruly will certainly lead a
Life of incessant heartache: that's an incurable evil.
Thus it is possible neither to fool Zeus nor circumvent his
Wits, for not even Prometheus, Iapetus's son, although clever,
Could quite get himself out from the yoke of his heavy displeasure,
But necessarily, smart though he was, strong bondage repressed him.
So at the first when their father was angry with stout Briareus,
Cottus, and Gyges, he bound them in strong, irrefrangible bondage;
Being resentful at heart of their mettlesome manliness, beauty,
Also their great size, Uranus banished them under the broad earth;
There underground they abode in much torment, discomfort, and anguish,
Stuck at the ends of the earth, at the ultimate limits of great earth,

Bitter at heart for a long while, suffering grievous affliction.
These did the offspring of Cronus, as well as the other immortal
Gods whom Rhea, the well-coiffed, bore in conjunction with Cronus,
Bring up again into daylight at the advisement of Earth, for
She explained everything thoroughly to them, how with the help of
Uranus's sons they would win bright victory such as they prayed for.
For the Titanic immortals and those begotten by Cronus
Long had been struggling against each other in fierce internecine
Combat, exerting themselves together in heart-wrenching effort,
On one side the illustrious Titans from lofty Mount Othrys[39]
And on the other the gods from Olympus, the givers of good things,
Those whom Rhea the fair-haired bore after sleeping with Cronus.
So at that time they were fighting continually with each other
Ten full years as they nursed in their guts indigestible anger.
Nor was there any solution or end to the difficult conflict
For either side, but the outcome of battle was equally balanced.
But when Zeus, in the meanwhile, had furnished his monsters with all things
Suitable, nectar as well as ambrosia, foods that the gods eat,
Then did the manly spirit of all three swell in their bosoms.
When they had eaten their fill of delicious ambrosia and of
Nectar, then Zeus, the begetter of gods and of humans, addressed them:
"Listen to me, you glorious children of Earth and of Heaven,
So I may say those things that the heart in my bosom commands me.
Every day for a long time now have we offspring of Cronus
Vied with the Titans for power and victory, fighting each other.
Show, for your own part, maintain your immense strength and resistless
Arms in opposing the Titans in bitter, lugubrious battle,
Mindful of all our considerate kindness: haven't you come back
Up to the light after what you endured in uncomfortable bondage
Under the mist-filled darkness, all through our inscrutable plans?"

39. In Thessaly; see map.

So he declared, and in answer excellent Cottus responded.
"Sir, you reveal to us nothing we aren't aware of already.
Well do we know your intelligence, also your high understanding;
You have become the defender of all the immortals from cold war.
For it is thanks to your thoughtfulness we have returned back again from
Out of the mist-filled darkness and out of our merciless bondage,
Having experienced things unhoped for, O lord, son of Cronus!
So, with inflexible purpose and after considerate planning,
We shall assist your all-powerful might in this terrible battle,
Struggling against all those Titans in strong-armed personal duels."
That was his speech, and the deities, givers of bounty, commended
What he had said when they'd heard him. Their spirit was keener for warfare
Than in the past, and they roused themselves up to regrettable battle
That very day, every one of them, females and males all together,
Both all the gods called Titans and those who descended from Cronus,
Also the monsters whom Zeus brought up to the light from Erebus
Under the earth, fierce, fearsome, and strong, irresistibly well armed,
For from the shoulders of all of them equally sprouted a hundred
Hands; from the shoulders of each of these creatures as well grew fifty
Heads in a similar manner on top of their powerful bodies.
These, as they stood up against the Titans in furious face-off,
Grasped in their powerful hands unwieldy, precipitous boulders,
And on the other hand, meanwhile, the Titans in zeal reinforced their
Ranks, so both the opponents displayed their physical strength and
Manual labor. The limitless ocean resounded about them,
And earth crashed in a spasm, the wide sky groaned and was shaken;
Even the heights of Olympus quaked to their very foundations
Under the force of the charge of the deathless immortals, the heavy
Shock of whose trampling feet reached even to Tartarus, with the
High thrilling cries of unspeakable onslaught and clanging of heavy
Blows as they hurled at each other their grievous, lamentable missiles.

Then did the noise of their voices when shouting arise to the starry
Heavens; they rushed all together with battle cries loudly resounding.
Neither did Zeus restrain any longer his strength, but his mind now
Forthwith was filled with the sense of his might, and he showed forth his power,
All of it, all at one time; from Olympus as well as from heaven,
Constantly hurling his lightning, he strode along so that the thunder
Bolts flew thick and fast from his muscular hand, intermingled
Thunder and lightning together, both whirling around in a sacred
Burning; the life-giving earth shook on all sides as it kindled
Ablaze, and the huge wood rattled and crashed in the great fire;
All of the land boiled over as well as the waters of Ocean
And the unharvested sea. Hot vapors enveloped the earth-born
Titans; unchecked combustion invaded the radiant upper
Air, and the brilliant and glittering glare of the thunder and lightning
Dazzled them, strong though they were, temporarily blinding their eyes.
Then the miraculous fiery heat reached down into Chaos.
It was as if one watched with his eyes and heard with his ears the
Earth and the heavens above it collapsing on top of each other:
Such the great thud that would rise if the heavens were falling and from the
Earth that they fell on as came from the strife of the gods in collision.
With this the winds brought gravelly earthquake and stifling windstorm,
Thunder and lightning, and also the glistening thunderbolt, weapons
Of great Zeus, as they carried the noise and the shouts of the battle
Into the midst of both camps. A gargantuan racket arose of
Terrible strife, and the strength of their bellicose arms was apparent
Even as fighting declined; but before that they held one another
Off as they fought without ceasing in vigorous, fierce, single combats.
Then Briareus and Cottus and Gyges, unwearied with battle,
First in the forefront, engaged in insatiate, bitterest fighting,
Sending one after another three hundred rocks from their strong hands

To overshadow the Titans with missiles; they sent them beneath the
Widely trod earth, and they bound them with troublesome bonds, having conquered
Them with their hands in despite of the Titans' arrogant spirit,
Under the earth just as far as the heavens are over the earth, for
Such is the distance from earth into nebulous Tartarus. A bronze
Anvil that fell from the sky for ten nights and ten days on the tenth would
Come to the earth, and once more a bronze anvil that fell from the earth to
Tartarus for ten nights and ten days would arrive on the tenth day.
All about Tartarus marches a bronze palisade, and around the
Neck of it night extends in threefold layers; above it
Flourish the roots of the earth and the sea, which forever is fallow.
There the Titanic divinities under that nebulous darkness
Welter, concealed in a place that is foul, at the ends of the huge earth
All through the far-sighted plans of Zeus, who marshals the storm clouds.
There is no exit for them, for Poseidon has fitted there doors of
Bronze, and a wall which extends all along on both sides of the doorway.
Also magnanimous Briareus and Cottus and Gyges
Live there, the trusty defenders of Zeus, who is lord of the aegis.
There in a row all in order the ultimate sources and limits
Stand, of the darkling earth and of nebulous Tartarus, also
Of the unharvested sea as well as the star-studded heavens,
Loathsome, malodorous, foul—and indeed the immortals detest them.
Vast is that chasm, and nobody could, if a year were completed,
Get through it all after first having entered its gateway, for cruel
Wind upon wind would transport him cruelly hither and thither.
This is a fearful and marvelous thing to the deities even.
There stands the awful home of black Night, enveloped in blue clouds.
Standing in front of its doorway, the son of Iapetus, Atlas,

Holds on his head and his hands, unfatigued and immobile, the wide sky,
Even where Night and Day as they pass one another salute each
Other on crossing the great bronze threshold; while one is descending
Into their dwelling, the other is going abroad through the doorway,
Nor does that mansion at any one time entertain them together.
One of them always is out of the house as she passes above the
Earth, while the other abides in the home where she stays to await the
Hour of departure, whenever it comes; and when one of them holds the
Light that illumines all people who dwell on the earth, the
Other, lamentable Night, enveloped in nebulous darkness,
Holds in mysterious arms that Sleep which is brother to Death.
That is the place where the children of black Night have their apartments,
Namely, Sleep and Death, who are awful divinities, and the
Radiant sun never gazes upon them with glittering sunbeams
As he ascends into heaven and as he descends from the heavens;
Of these, the former meanders across the wide earth and the broad-backed
Sea and is peaceful and pleasant to men, but the other one's heart is
Iron, his character pitiless, harder than bronze, for whichever
Human he catches he grasps, and he's hateful to all the immortals.
Furthermore, there the reverberant halls of the god of the nether
World, strong, powerful Hades, and dreadful Persephone, his queen,
Stand, and a fearful and pitiless watchdog guards them in front. That
Hound has a wicked trick, for he fawns with his tail and his ears on
Those going in, but he doesn't permit anybody to go out.
Watching, he catches and eats anyone going out by the gateway.
There is the dwelling as well of the goddess abhorred by immortals,
Terrible Styx, the most senior daughter of retrograde Ocean.
Far from the gods, she inhabits a glorious house overhung by
Sizable rocks, and with silvery columns surrounding it all, it

Rises right up to the sky. Not too often the daughter of Thaumas,
Swift-footed Iris, traverses the broad-backed sea to deliver
There any message. However, when discord and quarrels among the
Deathless are stirred up, Zeus sends Iris to fetch in a golden
Pitcher the gods' great oath from afar, the notorious, chilly
Stygian water that trickles down from precipitous heights.
Flowing a long way under the wide-traveled earth from the sacred
River, a branch of the Ocean cascades through the blackness of night. A
Tenth of the waters of Ocean belong to the Styx as her birthright.
Swirling in nine silver eddies, the stream that encircles the earth and
Broad-backed sea falls into the briny, but this one alone, which
Springs from a rock in the sight of the gods, is a major misfortune.
One of the gods who inhabit the snow-covered peaks of Olympus,
When he has poured a libation to Styx, if he perjures himself, lies
Breathless and doesn't draw breath till the whole of a year is completed.
Nor does he ever approach to partake of ambrosia or of
Nectar, but lies without spirit or voice on a bed that is spread with
Bedclothes; and him a malignant and magical slumber envelops.
Once he has done with that illness and come to the end of a long year,
After that trial, another and harder one follows, one fast on another;
For from the gods, whose life is eternal, he's sundered for nine years,
Never to mix in their councils nor join in theirs feasts for the whole nine
Years. In the tenth he rejoins the assemblies of all the immortal
Gods on Olympus. So such is the oath that they swear by the ancient,
Ageless, primordial water of Styx, and it springs from a hard place.
There in a row all in order the ultimate sources and limits
Stand, of the darkling earth and of nebulous Tartarus, also
Of the unharvested sea as well as the star-studded heavens,
Loathsome, malodorous, foul—and indeed the immortals detest them.
There are the glistening gates and the threshold of natural bronze set
Fast and immovable, fixed to continuous, rooted foundations.
Outside and beyond these, apart from the other divinities, dwell the
Titans over against inarticulate Chaos; however,

Cottus and Gyges, the glorious allies of stentorian Zeus, keep
House in the depths of the ocean. However, Poseidon, the heavy
Thundering earth-quaker, made Briareus, because he was brave, his
Son-in-law, giving him Cympolea, his daughter, in marriage.

Then, after Zeus had expelled the Titans from heaven, prodigious
Earth gave birth to the last of her children, Typhoeus, enduring
Sexual union with Tartarus, prompted by gold Aphrodite.
Strong were his hands in defense and in all his endeavors, his feet were
Strong and unwearying, those of a robust divinity. From his
Shoulders a hundred serpentine heads like a terrible dragon's
Sprouted with pitchy, flickering tongues; from the eyes underneath the
Brows in these magical heads, a malevolent fire coruscated.
From all these heads, as he glared all about him, a fire was blazing,
And there were voices inside these terrible heads which projected
Every sort of unspeakable voice, for at one time they uttered
Speech such as gods understand, and at others the sound of a loudly
Bellowing bull in the pride of unbridled ferocity; then once
More he would roar like a lion of impudent courage, then whimper
Puppylike, wondrous to hear, then hiss till the high hills resounded.
Then would a deed beyond any recourse have been done on that same
day,
And this Typhoeus would surely have ruled the immortals and mortals
Had not the father of gods and of men been sharp to take notice.
Mightily, harshly he thundered, so loud that the earth all around shook,
Making a terrible noise, like the far-reaching heavens above, the
Sea and the streams of the ocean, the pits of the underworld also.
Mighty Olympus unsteadily tottered beneath the immortal
Feet of its lord in arousal, and earth sympathetically groaned. The
Heat that emitted from both of them seized on the violet-hued sea,
Blazes of thunder and lightning as well as the fire from the monster's
Burning, the hurricane winds and the thunderbolts' sizzle and crackle.
All of the earth boiled up, and the sky and the sea in addition.

Round and about all the headlands and beaches the breakers were crashing
Under the charge of the gods; there occurred an unquenchable earthquake.
Hades, who governs the dead in his underworld kingdom, was frightened,
So were the Titans, who dwell under Tartarus, round about Cronus,
By that unquenchable racket and horrible clangor of battle.
Zeus, when he'd gathered his strength and taken hold of his weapons,
Thunder and lightning contained in a bright-burning thunderbolt, leaping
Down from Olympus impulsively, struck at Typhoeus and set on
Fire all the marvelous heads of the monster that sprouted all over
Him. Then, when Zeus had subdued him and whipped him again and again with
Lashes of lightning, he hurled him down, crippled; the monstrous earth groaned.
Flames shot out of the thunderstruck deity where he'd been stricken
Down to the earth in the rough, inaccessible dells of the mountain.
Much of the monstrous earth was dissolved by that weird exhalation,
Melting like tin that is heated by technical means by some sturdy
Workmen in pervious crucibles, or like iron, the strongest
Element, tamed and refined by a hot-burning fire in the mountain
Dales, which is smelted in godly earth by the might of Hephaestus.
So earth melted at once in a flash of that blazing and glistening fire.
Into broad Tartarus Zeus, being angered, ejected Typhoeus.
And from Typhoeus arises the force of the humidly blowing
Winds, except Notus and Boreas and wholesome, brightening Zephyr,
Winds that are born of the gods, a magnificent blessing for humans.
Every which way and at random those other winds blow on the sea and,
Fitfully rising and falling, descend on the cloud-covered deep, a
Terrible trial for men with their boisterous, roistering breezes;
Blowing in different directions at different seasons, they scatter

Vessels and murder their mariners. There is no help for such ills for
Seafaring men who encounter breezes like these on the deep sea.
Furthermore, raging all over the limitless, flowery earth, they
Ruin the beautiful works of mankind, who are earth-generated,
Filling their fields and their dwellings with dust and a horrible uproar.
Then at last, when the blessed divinities finished their labor,
Having decided by force their rights in regard to the Titans,
Then they invited Olympian, wide-eyed Zeus to become the
Ruler and king of the gods, as advised by the earth goddess, Gaia.
That being settled, he split their prerogative honors among them.
Zeus, being king, first married the goddess of practical reason,
Metis, the wisest, most knowledgeable of immortals or mortals.
But, just as she was about to give birth to gray-eyed Athena,
Zeus, at that moment misleading her wits by a cunning deception
And with his flattering arguments, swallowed her into his stomach,
At the advice of the earth goddess, Gaia, and star-studded Heaven.
For they instructed him thusly, in order that none of the other
Gods whose race is eternal should get royal power but Zeus.
All too intelligent children were destined to come out of Metis;
First was the gray-eyed maiden Athena, called Tritogeneia,[40]
Who, in intelligent counsel and forcefulness, equals her father.
Afterward, Metis was going to bear him a son of a reckless
Character, larger than life, future king of the gods and of men, too;
But Zeus, before she could do so, swallowed her into his belly,
So that the goddess might teach him the meaning of good and of evil.
Second, he wed brilliant Themis, the goddess of law and tradition,
Who bore him the Hours and Eunomia, Dike, and fruitful Irene—
Order and Justice and Peace—regulating the works of us mortals,
Also the Fates, whom considerate Zeus paid the greatest respect to:
Clotho, Lachesis, and Atropos, giver of men's good and evil.

40. Various fanciful, geographical explanations are given for this stock epithet of Athena, but the most likely seems to derive it from an Aeolic word meaning "born from the head."

Next did Eurynome, she who possessed a surpassingly pretty,
Lovely appearance, the daughter of Ocean, bear the three Graces,
Namely, Aglaia, as well as Euphrosyne, Thalia also.
Graceful indeed, for, from under their eyelids, love—which undoes the
Limbs—drips; under their eyebrows, beauty entrancingly glances.
Next Zeus went to the bed of Demeter, who nourishes many,
Who gave birth to Persephone with her white arms, whom Hades
Snatched from her mother; and Zeus, in his wisdom, gave her to Hades.
And yet again to exquisite Mnemosyne—Memory—Zeus made
Love, and from her the nine Muses with golden tiaras were born; to
Them festive banquets are pleasing, as well as the pleasure of music.
Leto, uniting in fondness with Zeus, who is Lord of the aegis,
Bore him far-shooting Apollo and Artemis, shooter of arrows,
Lovely, desirable children above all the offspring of heaven.
Finally, Zeus made Hera his beautiful, flourishing consort;
Hebe and Ares[41] she bore and Eileithyia, goddess of childbirth,
After uniting in love with the king of the gods and of humankind.
All by himself, from his head, Zeus fathered gray-eyed Athena,
Terrible rouser to battle and leader of armies, that tireless
Lady whose pleasure is ever in war cries and warfare and fighting.
Hera engendered the craftsman Hephaestus, not having engaged in
Marital intercourse, for she had quarreled, annoyed with her
husband—
Famous Hephaestus, surpassing in handwork all the immortals.
From Amphitrite and noisy Poseidon, the maker of earthquakes,
Mighty, loud-trumpeting Triton was born, who inhabits the sea depths,
Where, with the mother he loves and his lordly progenitor, in a
Mansion of gold he abides, and an awesome divinity he is!
But Aphrodite, in union with shield-breaking Ares, gave birth to
Terror and Dread, those terrible ones who dissipate human
Battle formations in cold-blooded war with the sacker of cities,

41. Mars in Latin, the god of war.

Ares, Harmonia also, whom high-minded Cadmus espoused.
Maia, Atlas's daughter, bore Zeus glorious Hermes,
Herald of blessed immortals, having got into his blest bed.
Semele, daughter of Cadmus, having united in love with
Zeus, gave birth to a splendid son, Dionysus, the cheerful
God, an immortal though she was a mortal; but now they are both gods.
Also Alcmene, uniting in sexual congress with Zeus, who
Gathers the clouds, bore powerful, muscular Heracles to him.
Furthermore, famous Hephaestus, the splay-footed craftsman,
espoused the
Youngest of Graces, Aglaia, and made her his blossoming wife.
And golden-locked Dionysus espoused fair-haired Ariadne,
Daughter of Minos of Crete, and he made her his blossoming wife.
For him, the scion of Cronus made her immortal and ageless.
Heracles, virile and valiant son of trim-ankled Alcmene,
When he had finished his tiresome trials, took as his blooming
Wife upon snowy Olympus Hebe, the child of almighty
Zeus and of Hera, whose sandals are golden; and blessed he is who,
Having accomplished his great undertaking among the immortals,
Lives beyond all human suffering, ageless for all of his days.
Perseis, well-known and beauteous daughter of Ocean, presented
The inexhaustible Sun with Aeetes, the monarch, and Circe.[42]
Kingly Aeetes, the son of the sun, who illuminates mankind
Married Idyia, whose cheeks were so fair, to fulfill the divine scheme,
Maidenly daughter of Ocean, the perfect and ultimate river.
She in her turn bore Medea,[43] whose ankles were trim after being
Subject to sexual love by the working of gold Aphrodite.

Now farewell to all you who inhabit the halls of Olympus,
Islands and continents, too, and the salt sea between and among them!

42. Enchantress and priestess in Odyssey, book 10.
43. Also a witch, heroine of the Argonautica and a play by Euripides.

Sing of the races of goddesses now, and the sweet-spoken Muses,
Daughters conceived on Olympus by Zeus, who is lord of the aegis,
Who, when they bedded with men who were mortal, although they themselves were
Deathless, conceived and brought forth mortal children resembling the gods.
Goddess of goddesses, queenly Demeter, gave birth to the noble
Demigod Plutus (or Wealth) after lying in love in a fallow
Field that had thrice been plowed with heroic Iasion[44] in the
Fertile and prosperous country of Crete. A goodly divinity, Plutus
Travels all over the earth and the broad-backed sea, and to one who
Has the good fortune to find him and into whose hands he may fall,
Plutus gives plenty of money and makes him a prosperous man.
Daughter of gold Aphrodite, Harmonia brought forth for Cadmus[45]
Ino and Semele, also the naiad, sweet-cheeked Agave,
Plus Autonoe, who wedded long-haired Aristaeus and bore him
Prince Polydorus in Thebes all encircled with ramparts and towers.
Also a daughter of Ocean, the nymph Callirhoe, in loving
Union with strong-willed Chrysaor, obeying the will of the splendid
Goddess of love, Aphrodite, gave birth to the strongest of mankind,
Geryon, whom stout Heracles killed on account of some round-hoofed
Cattle that Heracles stole on the sea-bound isle Erytheia.
Eos[46] bore to Tithonus a son, bronze-helmeted Memnon,
King of the black Ethiopians, lordly Emathion also.
Also, by Cephalus Eos engendered a glorious son, strong
Phaethon, who was a man who resembled the gods, and when he was
Only a youngster possessing the delicate blossom of splendid

44. Short-lived and insignificant, like most mortal consorts; see Odyssey, book 5, 125ff.

45. Credited with the introduction of writing in Greece and founder of Thebes, whose later history is too complex to recount here.

46. The dawn, Aurora in Latin, who granted eternal life to her lover, Tithonus, who forgot to ask for eternal youth also and became a cicada.

Boyhood, no more than a child with a childlike intelligence, smiling,
Lewd Aphrodite enraptured and raped him and made him a temple
Night watchman, deep in her holiest temple, a guardian spirit.
Jason the son of Aeson abducted the daughter of royal,
High-bred Aeetes, fulfilling the will of the gods, from Aeetes,
After performing the many and tiresome labors imposed by
Great king Pelias, that overbearing and arrogant, ruthless,
Vile evildoer. When Jason had finished these feats, he arrived,
After much toil, at Iolcus, and with him he brought on his swift ship
Roguish Medea, the daughter of royal Aeetes. In wifely
Duty to Jason, the shepherd and king of his people, she bore him
Little Medeus, whom Chiron, the centaur, the son of Phillyra,
Reared in the mountains. And so was accomplished the purpose of great Zeus.
As for the daughters of Nereus, called the old man of the sea,
Psamathe, queen among goddesses, bore from her love for Aeacus,
Prompted by bright Aphrodite, Phocus; and silvery-footed
Thetis gave birth to Achilles, the lion-heart, breaker of men.
And Aphrodite, the gorgeously garlanded goddess of love, in
Union with virile Anchises, bore him heroic Aeneas
High on the summit of wooded, wrinkled, and windswept Mount Ida.
Circe, the daughter of Helios, son of Hyperion, had from
Sexual congress with clever and patient Odysseus offspring,
Agrius; also unblemished, impeccable, sturdy Latinus;
And Telegonus as well, via aureate Aphrodite.
Over the far-famed Tyrhenians all tucked away in the holy
Islands they rule. But Calypso, that lady divinity, being
Mixed up in sexual love with Odysseus, bore Nausithous.
These are the goddesses who, while immortal, consorted with mortal
Men and conceived and brought forth mortal children resembling the gods.
Now, about womankind sing, sweet-voiced Olympian Muses,
Daughters of almighty Zeus, who is master and lord of the aegis.

THE HOMERIC HYMNS

THE BATTLE OF THE FROGS AND THE MICE

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

In this version of what might be called the "Rhapsodies and Prefaces of the Sons of Homer," I have imitated the meter and diction of the original, in an attempt to give some taste of the peculiar flavor of these hymns, which seem at once solemn and facetious, gay and grand. My dactylic hexameters I allow to contain more undiluted dactyls than the Greek; the lines are, with few exceptions, purely dactylic through the fifth foot; the sixth foot is more often trochaic than spondaic, as the rules of classical scansion would approve. The reason for the predominance of dactyls lies in the accentual character of the English language, where spondees are few and three stressed syllables (as must arise in the case of a spondee followed by a dactyl), almost unheard of. The effect here, though more monotonous, is lighter than that of the original and at least avoids those confusing hiatuses that result from any attempt to write true classical hexameters in English. So powerful has the dactylic rhythm proved, in fact, that I have taken liberties with the accents of certain words for prosodic reasons, much as a composer might set the occasional syllable in such a way as to outrage its spoken pattern while preserving his tune. Thus, while "immortal" and "undying" are accented on the penult, both seem to me defensibly to scan as dactyls because of the audible length of the first foot. Readers are not to quibble at syllables if they hear throughout the steady measure of the hexameter.

The diction of the *Homeric Hymns* presents as many problems in English as it does in Greek. Composed, at a most conservative estimate, over a period of a thousand years—from 600 BC to AD 400—these lays and invocations in the Homeric style are, like all classical poetry, often deliberately archaic and almost invariably precious. Of great lexicographical interest, they present many odd and out of the way usages and abound, as their frequent citations in Liddell and Scott's Greek dictionary show, in *hapax legomena*. My rule has been to follow the sense, and sometimes the

sound, of the Greek as closely as possible, letting archaisms and colloquialisms equally intrude when they seemed called for or inevitable, but avoiding an unduly up-to-date contemporary style. The bards who composed these songs for recitation were, despite their beards and their beggary, no Beats; they are, rather, our—as they were Chapman's and Shelley's and the Greeks'—chief instructors in classical language and literature.

I have not invariably reproduced in position the celebrated formulary epithets and phrases so typical of this once oral poetry, and I have, from a strict constructionist's point of view, culpably, even whimsically, varied the translation of any given stock expression. The modern ear and, what is more important, the modern eye like variety; so *hekatabolos*, the most common title of Apollo, becomes in turn "long-distance archer," "accurate marksman," "Guard from afar." Yet I trust that enough of the repetitive, comfortable character of the original recitation persists to give all but bronze age purists an adequate impression of the incantatory, formal quality of the hymns: "Ah, humankind must endure all the gifts of the gods, though we suffer!"

Finally, it has been my aim to capture also the different tones of voice of the divine protagonists and the idiosyncratic styles of the various hymns. Thus, the *Hymn to Demeter* (II) has a plainness which, in the *Hymn to Pythian Apollo* (III) degenerates into pomposity, as the slyness of *To Aphrodite* (V) explodes into the slapstick of *To Hermes* (IV).

I have preserved the arrangement of the hymns in their classical order, that of most manuscripts and editions, for want of a better. This order would appear to be roughly chronological according to some theory of date of composition. Hymns I, II, and III certainly seem older, rougher, and more "authentic," while XXX, XXXI, and XXXII seem modern to the point of triviality. An accident of this arrangement is that the longer, narrative hymns (II, III, IV, and V), the major hymns which anyone at all familiar with minor Homerica has read, come first, while the frequently charming, slighter, and later hymns, VIII through XXXIII, are relegated by most readers to neglect. The only obvious alternative was to arrange the poems alphabetically, according to deity, as a sort of Olympian directory, or pantheon, from Aphrodite to Zeus. This too had its drawbacks, notably an air of frivolity; if the present arrangement seems arbitrary, it has at least the sanction of tradition, and like the anonymous authors of these lyrics, I have preferred the familiar, as a rule,

to the newfangled and faddish. But I would encourage readers to take the *Homeric Hymns* in any order that they please, as I did in translating them, not following the sequence as set forth here, but beginning and ending where they like.

A burlesque rather than a serious parody or *imitatio Iliadis*, the *Batrachomyomachia* (or *The Battle of the Frogs and the Mice*) is—like the hymns, which it resembles at least in meter—of profoundly uncertain date and authorship, the guesswork of Byzantine grammarians notwithstanding. This comic epyllion belongs, in all but specific mock-heroic reference, to a different literary genre, that of Aristophanes and Aesop, comedy and fable. Unlike the inimitable *Homeric Hymns*, it has been much imitated, as by Vergil in his (?) *Culex*, and Henryson in his *Taill of the Paddok and the Mous*; Rabelais remembers it in *La guerre des andouillettes*, and the *Rape of the Lock* and *Animal Farm* are equally indebted to this anonymous progenitor. Broad in tone, zoomorphic in cast, *The Battle* is a takeoff on the attitudes and epithets of Homeric heroism as seen by a later, softer age. It makes the Olympian deities not merely human but all too human—peevish, ineffectual, and neurotic to a degree unexampled even in the *Iliad*—and far from their aspect in the hymns, in even the latest of which the gods are treated with a real, if at times tender or amused, awe.

Lucian almost might have perpetrated this poem. Its interest for the translator lay in the challenge presented by the ridiculous but apt names of the protagonists and the slapstick battle scenes. Its appeal for the reader should consist in the literary absurdity and microcosmic rough-and-tumble fun of the action, which suggests some Hellenistic Mickey Mouse cartoon.

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